

"I feel very friendly towards your country, but make

BARON OF BATON

Neither a diplomat nor a politician, the globe-trotting conductor has turned western classical music into a powerful touchstone for dialogue between warring nations, a balm to the wounds of war

■ By Lavina Melwani

Can a conductor's baton be the catalyst for a more peaceful world? In the hands of maestro Zubin Mehta, it has turned into a lightning rod for harmony: he has conducted Jewish musicians in the shadow of the Nazi concentration camps and even played Wagner to Jewish audiences. "I took the Israel Philharmonic to Nazareth and performed for a completely Arab audience," he recalls. "They gave us a standing ovation. Imagine Arabs standing up for a hundred Jews playing on stage? It's very healthy. It doesn't change the West Bank problems but it brings some goodwill at least." Calming troubled waters with music is something Mehta has always done: in 1988, he conducted the New York Philharmonic Orchestra with the State Symphony Orchestra in Moscow; in 1994 when there were icy relations between Israel and India, he brought the Israel Philharmonic Orchestra to his homeland to create a thaw.

Born in 1936 in Bombay, Mehta's late father Mehli Mehta, conductor of the Bombay Symphony Orchestra, held makeshift rehearsals in the family living room, bringing the rich world of western classical music into the home. Music came as naturally as breathing to the future maestro and at the age of two, he often slept with a pair of cherished drumsticks under his pillow at night.

The world might have lost out on a legendary conductor, had not Mehta given up his pre-medical studies at 18

to pursue his real passion. In spite of financial constraints, the Mehtas sent him to Vienna's prestigious Akademie für Musik where he entered the conducting programme under Hans Swarowsky. Money was so tight that when he needed a full dress suit for conducting a concert as part of the final examination, he bought a passable substitute for \$25 from a place where waiters purchased their uniforms, and often wore two mismatched black shoes as the others had holes in them.

Graduating in 1957, his rising star was on a trajectory: he won the Liverpool International Conducting Competition in 1958 and by 1961, had already conducted the Vienna, Berlin, and Israel Philharmonic Orchestras. After that, he was the music director for the Montreal Symphony Orchestra, and then of the Los Angeles Philharmonic at the age of 26. He became music director of the New York Philharmonic in 1978, commencing a 13-year tenure, the longest in the history of the Philharmonic.

Since 1985, Mehta has been chief conductor of the Orchestra del Maggio Musicale Fiorentino in Florence, and has also served as music director of the Bavarian State Opera. He is an honorary citizen of both Florence and Tel Aviv, and an honorary member of the Vienna State Opera. In 2006, he opened the Palau de les Arts Reina Sofia in Valencia followed by a three-year project of Richard Wagner's Ring des Nibelungen cycle in the production of the Fura del Baus of Barcelona in Valencia and Florence.

Mehta has had a long relationship with the Israeli Philharmonic and is its music director for life. Apart from a pure passion for music, the main thrust of his work is using music as an agent for change. "My dream really is to have an Arab Israeli playing in the Israel Philharmonic," he says. His vast repertoire encompasses Bach, Mozart and Beethoven to Bartok and Schoenberg. Ask him about his favourite composer and he says, "There's no favourite composer—I do music that covers 400 years so I can't afford to have favourites."

A proud Parsi, Mehta is a prouder Indian who even after decades of living abroad still retains his Indian passport. India is a piece of his heart and his thoughts always turn to his favourite city by the Arabian Sea. He is passionate about Indian food, old friendships and the music school he has started in India in his father's name. This October, he will take the Israel Philharmonic Orchestra to Mumbai for a celebration of his late parents' 100th birth anniversary and to raise funds for the school. "There's a lot of talent in India—we now have to nurture it so they don't have to leave the country like a lot of us had to," he says.

Indeed, already there are several Indian musicians in world class orchestras abroad. For them, an impossible dream became a reality because Zubin Mehta led the way. They could dare to do it because he did it first.

The author is a New York-based journalist